

Jerome 378

Ep. 15, to Pope Damasus, complete — the chair of Peter and the communion-test (c. 376/7; CSEL 54, pp. 62–67)

XV. To Damasus.

1. Since the East, dashed together by the ancient frenzy of its peoples, is tearing to shreds, piece by piece, the seamless tunic of the Lord woven from the top, and the foxes are laying waste the vineyard of Christ, so that among the broken cisterns which hold no water it is hard to make out where the sealed fountain and that enclosed garden may be, I have therefore judged that I must consult the chair of Peter and the faith praised by an apostolic mouth, now begging from thence food for my soul, from the source whence of old I received the garments of Christ. Neither indeed could the vast waste of the flowing element nor the intervening length of lands hold me back from the search for the precious pearl. Wherever the body shall be, there will the eagles also be gathered together. When the patrimony has been squandered by wicked offspring, among you alone the inheritance of the fathers is preserved uncorrupted. There the earth, with fertile turf, renders the purity of the Lord's seed back a hundredfold; here the grain, buried in the furrows, degenerates into darnel and wild oats. Now in the West the Sun of righteousness is rising; but in the East that Lucifer who had fallen has set his throne above the stars. You are the light of the world, you are the salt of the earth, you are vessels of gold and silver; here are vessels of clay or of wood, awaiting the iron rod and everlasting burning.
2. Although, therefore, your greatness alarms me, yet your kindness invites me. From the priest I demand the victim of salvation, from the shepherd the protection of the sheep. Away with envy; let the ambition of the Roman height withdraw: it is with the successor of the fisherman and the disciple of the cross that I speak. Following no one as first except Christ, I am joined in communion with your Blessedness, that is, with the chair of Peter. Upon that rock I know the Church is built. Whoever eats the lamb outside this house is profane. If anyone has not been in the ark of Noah, he shall perish when the flood prevails. And because for my misdeeds I have migrated to that solitude which bounds Syria along its border adjoining the barbarian country, and cannot always seek the Lord's holy thing from your Holiness across so many intervening spaces, I therefore follow here your colleagues, the Egyptian confessors, and, a little skiff, lie hidden beneath the cargo-ships. I do not know Vitalis, I reject Meletius, I am ignorant of Paulinus. Whoever gathers not with you scatters; that is, whoever is not of Christ is of Antichrist.
3. Now therefore — alas! — after the Nicene faith, after the decree of Alexandria, with the West equally joined to it, a novel term is exacted of me, a Roman, by the offspring of the Arians, the Campenses — the term “three hypostaseis.” Which apostles, I ask, handed these things down? What new Paul, teacher of the nations,

taught this? We ask what they suppose can be understood by “three hypostases”: “three subsisting persons,” they say. We reply that we so believe; the sense does not satisfy them, they demand the very word, because I know not what poison lurks in the syllables. We cry aloud: “If anyone does not confess three hypostases as three *enhypostata*, that is, as three subsisting persons, let him be anathema”; and because we do not utter the vocables, we are judged heretics. But if anyone, understanding *hypostasis* as *ousia*, does not affirm one hypostasis in three persons, he is a stranger to Christ, and under this profession we too are branded, together with you, with the searing-iron of “union.”

4. Decide, I beg: if it please you, I shall not fear to speak of three hypostases; if you command it, let a new creed be framed after the Nicene, and in words like the Arians’ let us the orthodox make our confession. The whole school of secular letters knows *hypostasis* to be nothing other than *ousia*. And will anyone, I ask, with sacrilegious mouth proclaim three substances? God’s nature alone is one, which truly is — for that which subsists derives its being from no other source, but is its own — whereas the rest, which have been created, even though they seem to be, are not, because there was a time when they were not, and that which once was not can again cease to be. God alone, who is eternal, that is, who has no beginning, truly holds the name of essence. Therefore also he speaks to Moses from the bush: “I am who I am,” and again: “He who is has sent me.” There existed indeed at that time angels, heaven, earth, and seas: and how does God claim as proper to himself the common name of essence? But because that nature alone is uncreated, and in three persons one Godhead subsists, which truly is, it is one nature: whoever says there are three things, that is, three hypostaseis, under the name of piety attempts to assert three natures. And if it is so, why are we separated from Arius only by a partition-wall, being joined with him in perfidy? Let Ursinus be joined with your Blessedness, let Auxentius be allied with Ambrose! Far be this from the Roman faith! Let not the devout hearts of the peoples drink in so great a sacrilege. Let it suffice us to say one substance, three subsisting persons, perfect, equal, coeternal; let three hypostases be passed over in silence, if it please you, and let one be maintained. It is not a mark of good faith when, in the same meaning, the words disagree. Let the belief already stated suffice us; or, if you think it right, write that we ought to speak of three hypostases with their interpretations. We do not refuse — but, believe me, poison lurks beneath the honey. The angel of Satan has transfigured himself into an angel of light: they interpret *hypostasis* rightly, and when I say that I hold the very thing which they expound, I am judged a heretic. Why do they cling so anxiously to one word? Why do they lurk beneath ambiguous speech? If they believe as they interpret, I do not condemn what they hold; if I believe as they pretend to think, let them permit me to speak their meaning in my own words.
5. Wherefore I beseech your Blessedness, by the Crucified, the salvation of the world, by the consubstantial Trinity, that authority be granted me by your letters, whether the hypostases are to be kept silent or to be spoken of. And lest perchance the obscurity of the place in which I dwell mislead the bearers of the letters, deign to send your writings to Evagrius the presbyter, whom you know very well. At the same time, too, signify with whom I ought to communicate at Antioch, since the Campenses, joining themselves with the Tarsensian heretics, aim at nothing else than that, propped up by the authority of your communion, they may preach three hypostases in the old sense.

Ep. 16, to Pope Damasus, complete — with whom in Syria I ought to communicate (CSEL 54, pp. 68–69)

XVI. To Damasus.

1. The importunate woman in the Gospel deserved at last to be heard, and, though the door was shut with the servants inside and it was the middle of the night, friend received loaves from friend; God himself, who can be overcome by no forces set against him, is conquered by the prayers of the publican; the city of Nineveh, which had perished by its sin, stood firm by its weeping. To what purpose is all this, fetched with so long a preamble? Namely, that you may look upon one who is of little account, that you, a rich shepherd, may not despise the sick sheep. Christ carried the thief from the cross into paradise and, lest anyone should ever think conversion too late, made a martyrdom out of the penalty of murder. Christ, I say, joyfully embraces the returning prodigal son, and, the ninety-nine sound sheep left behind, the one little ewe that remained is carried home on the shoulders of the good shepherd. Paul from a persecutor becomes a preacher; he is blinded in his carnal eyes that he may see the more with his mind, and he who was leading the bound servants of Christ to the council of the Jews afterward himself glories in the chains of Christ.
2. I therefore, as I have already written before, having received the garment of Christ in the city of Rome, am now held on the barbarous frontier of Syria. And, that you may not think this sentence upon me was another's, I myself determined what I deserved. But, as the pagan poet says: "He changes his sky, not his soul, who runs across the sea," so the unceasing enemy has followed me at my back, so that now I endure greater wars in the solitude. For here the Arian madness, propped up by the powers of the world, rages; here the Church, torn into three parts, hastens to snatch me to itself. The ancient authority of the monks dwelling round about rises up against me. I meanwhile keep crying out: "Whoever is joined to the chair of Peter is mine." Meletius, Vitalis, and Paulinus say that they cleave to you: I could believe it if one alone were asserting it; as it is, either two are lying or all three. Therefore I beseech your Blessedness by the cross of the Lord, by the necessary glory of our faith, his Passion: as you follow the apostles in honor, so may you follow them also in merit; so may you sit upon the throne with the Twelve who are to judge; so may another gird you when you are old, together with Peter; so may you attain the citizenship of heaven with Paul — that you signify to me by your letter with whom in Syria I ought to communicate. Do not despise the soul for which Christ died.

Ep. 130, § 16 — the faith of holy Innocent as the laywoman's rule (A.D. 414; CSEL 56/1, pp. 196–197)

16. I have almost passed over what is perhaps the chief thing. While you were a little girl, and Anastasius, a bishop of holy and blessed memory, was governing the Roman church, a savage tempest of heretics from the regions of the East attempted to pollute and undermine the simplicity of the faith which has been praised by the apostle's voice. But that man of most rich poverty and apostolic solicitude at once struck down the noxious head and silenced the hissing mouths of the hydra. And because I fear — nay, by report I have learned — that in certain persons those poisoned seed-plants still live and sprout, I think you must be forewarned, with the loving affection of charity, to hold the faith of holy Innocent, who is the successor and son of the apostolic chair and of the aforesaid man, and to receive no foreign doctrine, however

prudent and clever it may seem to you. For men of this sort are wont to mutter in corners and, as it were, to call in question the justice of God: “Why was that soul born in that province? What reason was there that some should be born of Christian parents, others among wild beasts and most savage nations, where there is no knowledge of God?” And when they have struck each simple soul as with a scorpion’s sting, and have made a place for themselves by the piercing wound, they pour in their poison: “Do you suppose it is for nothing that a tiny infant, who scarcely knows his mother by a smile and the cheerfulness of her face, who has done neither good nor evil, is seized by a demon, is oppressed by the royal disease, and endures those things which we see that impious men do not endure, while those who serve God do endure them? But if the judgments of the Lord are true, justified in themselves, and there is nothing unjust with God, we are compelled by very reason to believe that souls existed in the heavenly places and, because of certain ancient sins, were condemned into human bodies and, so to speak, buried, and that we in the vale of tears are paying the penalties of our sins. Whence the prophet also says: ‘Before I was humbled, I sinned,’ and: ‘Bring my soul out of prison,’ and: ‘Did this man sin, that he should be born blind, or his parents?’ and other things like these.” This impious and wicked doctrine was once current in Egypt and in the regions of the East, and now lurks in hiding, as in the dens of vipers, among very many, and defiles the purity of those regions, and, as by a hereditary evil, creeps among a few that it may reach the many — of which I am certain that, if you hear it, you will not receive it. For you have with you teachers approved before God, whose faith is the norm of doctrine. You understand what I mean — for God will give you understanding in all things — nor will you at once demand a reply against this most savage heresy, and things far worse than I have said, lest I seem not so much to have forbidden as to have advised, since it is the business of the present work to instruct a virgin, not to answer heretics. For the rest, all their frauds and mines, by which they strive to overthrow the truth, we have overthrown in another work, with God’s help, which, if you wish, we will readily and gladly send. For wares pressed upon one, they say, stink, and prices decrease by easy availability, which are always greater in scarcity.

Ep. 146, to Evangelus, complete — the anti-witness: the world greater than the city (CSEL 56/1, pp. 308–312)

CXLVI. To Evangelus the Presbyter.

1. We read in Isaiah: “The fool will speak foolish things.” I hear that a certain man has broken out into such madness as to set deacons before presbyters, that is, before bishops. For since the Apostle plainly teaches that presbyters are the same as bishops, how does the minister of tables and of widows presume, puffed up, to exalt himself above those at whose prayers the body and blood of Christ are confected? Do you ask for authority? Hear the testimony: “Paul and Timothy, servants of Christ Jesus, to all the saints in Christ Jesus who are at Philippi, with the bishops and deacons.” Do you wish another example too? In the Acts of the Apostles Paul thus speaks to the priests of one church: “Take heed to yourselves and to the whole flock, in which the Holy Spirit has placed you as bishops, that you should rule the Church of the Lord, which he acquired with his own blood.” And lest anyone should contentiously argue that there were several bishops in one church, hear yet another testimony, in which it is most manifestly proved that a bishop and a presbyter are the same: “For this cause I left you in Crete, that you should set right the things that were wanting and appoint presbyters throughout the cities, as I also charged you: if any be without crime, the husband of one wife, having faithful children, not accused of riotous living or unruly.

For a bishop must be without crime, as the steward of God.” And to Timothy: “Do not neglect the grace of prophecy that is given you by the laying on of the hands of the presbytery.” But Peter too, in his first epistle: “The presbyters that are among you I beseech, being a fellow-presbyter and a witness of the sufferings of Christ and a partaker of the glory that is to be revealed: shepherd the flock of Christ and oversee it, not by constraint, but willingly, according to God.” And this is expressed more significantly in Greek as *episkopeuontes*, whence also the name of “bishop” is derived. Do the testimonies of such great men seem trivial to you? Let the Gospel trumpet sound — the son of thunder, whom Jesus loved most, who drank streams of doctrine from the breast of the Savior: “The presbyter to the elect lady and to her children, whom I love in the truth”; and in another epistle: “The presbyter to the most beloved Gaius, whom I love in the truth.” But that afterward one was chosen who should be set over the rest, this was done as a remedy for schism, lest each one, dragging [the flock] to himself, should break apart the Church of Christ. For at Alexandria too, from Mark the Evangelist down to the bishops Heraclas and Dionysius, the presbyters always named as bishop one chosen from among themselves and set in a higher rank — just as if an army should make an emperor, or as if deacons should choose from among themselves one whom they know to be diligent and call him archdeacon. For what does a bishop do — ordination excepted — that a presbyter does not do? Nor is the church of the city of Rome to be reckoned one thing, and that of the whole world another. Both the Gauls and the Britains and Africa and Persia and the East and India and all the barbarian nations adore one Christ, observe one rule of truth. If authority is what is sought, the world is greater than the city. Wherever a bishop shall be — whether at Rome or at Gubbio or at Constantinople or at Rhegium or at Alexandria or at Tanis — he is of the same merit and of the same priesthood too. The power of riches and the lowliness of poverty make a bishop higher or lower; for the rest, all are successors of the apostles.

2. But you will say: “How is it that at Rome a presbyter is ordained upon the testimony of a deacon?” Why do you bring forward to me the custom of one city? Why do you claim the fewness from which arrogance has sprung as a law for the Church? Everything that is rare is the more coveted; pennyroyal among the Indians is more precious than pepper. It is their fewness that makes deacons honorable, while a crowd makes presbyters contemptible. Yet even in the church of Rome the presbyters sit and the deacons stand — although, as vices gradually increase, I have seen a deacon sit among presbyters in the bishop’s absence, and at private banquets give blessings to presbyters. Let those who do this learn that they do not act rightly, and let them hear the apostles: “It is not right that we should forsake the word of God and serve tables.” Let them know why deacons were instituted; let them read the Acts of the Apostles; let them remember their own condition. “Presbyter” and “bishop”: the one is a name of age, the other of office. Hence to Timothy and to Titus it is said, concerning the ordination of a bishop and of deacons, but of presbyters nothing at all is said, because in [the word] “bishop” the presbyter also is contained. He who is promoted is promoted from the lesser to the greater. Either, then, let a deacon be ordained out of a presbyter, so that the presbyter may be shown to be lesser than the deacon into whom he grows up from a small [rank]; or, if a presbyter is ordained out of a deacon, let him know himself to be lesser in earnings but greater in priesthood. And, that we may know the apostolic traditions to be taken from the Old Testament: what Aaron and his sons and the Levites were in the temple, this let bishops and presbyters and deacons claim for themselves in the Church.